	COMPLAINT AND APPEALS HANDLING PROCEDURE	
	Document no: ASMF 7.18	
Compiled by:	**Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager**	
Approved by:	**Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager**	

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Azuresky (Pty) Ltd strives to provide a reliable and smooth service for our customers, however no institution is perfect and occasionally it may be necessary to raise a concern regarding participation in proficiency tests and/or the production of certified reference materials.

Purpose

To define the process for receiving, evaluating, investigating, and resolving complaints and/or appeals.

Application

This procedure is to be applied by all persons including customer receiving complaints regarding the production, certification, packaging, labelling, and distribution of both proficiency testing samples and reference materials produced.

Responsibilities

Operations Manager: Reviews and approves final decisions and safeguards impartiality throughout the process

Laboratory Manager/Supervisor: Initiates technical investigations and oversees the complaint-handling process

Laboratory Technicians/Operators: Assists with technical investigations.

Procedure

- Complaints/appeals shall be received in writing through and logged in the complaints register
- Azuresky personnel shall acknowledge receipt of the complaint/appeals within the days' end and inform the initiator of the commitment to investigate and correct the error committed.
- Laboratory Manager/Supervisor shall confirm whether the complaint/appeal relates to activities of production/running of PT and reference material in the organisation.

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- Assign an investigator that is not involved in the area/department of where the error occurred, where appropriate.
- Gather all evidence needed for the investigation which will include but not be limited to test records, shipping logs and communication history.
- Determine if the complaint was valid.
- If so, was there an error, misunderstanding, or non-conformity?
- Document the necessary corrective/preventative action and prepare a formal response.
- Take the final decision after careful review of the evidence gathered and where necessary, consult with Operations Manager.
- Ensure that the Investigation and decision on complaints/appeals shall not result in any discriminatory actions.
- Communicate the official outcome to the complainant and if necessary, offer further assistance which may include replacement of a batch of certified reference material if appropriate.
- Ensure that the decision reviewed, approved and communicated to the complainant by individual(s) not involved in the original PT/RM activities in question
  NB: Where resources do not permit this, any alternative approach shall not compromise impartiality.
- Risk analysis shall be undertaken and logged in the risk register.

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Reference Material/Control Sample Failure Checklist

Good laboratories will report results within the manufacturers two standard deviation levels. If the customer's laboratory is not achieving that or if control sample results are failing the quality criteria that which customer's laboratory have set:

-Firstly

1. The lab shall check that they are using the correct Reference Material (with a grade or quality matching their samples).

2. Read the manufacturers certificate and make sure the control chart limits match or are within the certificate limits.

3. Note: if customer's laboratory has developed a bias, you will automatically see more failures.

-Check the product labelling to make sure you are using the correct Reference Material

1. Check that the Product Code on the packaging matches the Code in your QC program.

2. The Laboratory Pack (bottle/tub) containers are labelled and tamper proof. A label shall state a batch with a batch number (if appropriate), put on the bottle/tub during batch production. A label also shows product code. A large label is put on the tub during dispatch (applicable on large tub) and also shows the product (batch) code. The batch code must correspond with the product certificate (IF IT DOESN'T, IMMEDIATELY CONTACT Azuresky).

-Check that you are using appropriate limits

1. Check that you have set appropriate limits for that Reference Material for your laboratory (from your own results).

2. Check that you are applying the appropriate rules to accept or to fail a run

-You still have a problem:

3. Check that the matrix of the Reference Material matches or is close to the matrix of your samples and that the appropriate analytical techniques, etc. have been used for your matrix.

-Feel free to check the mathematics on the certificate.

1. Azuresky round robin data and statistics are published in the certificate and are available in a digital format on request.

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2. Azuresky round robin data and statistics are also available in the round robin proficiency report. These reports are made available to Laboratories that participate in the Azuresky round robins and customers may ask Laboratory Managers to see this report.

-Contact Azuresky

1. Find out, how much has been sold to other customers?

2. Have there been any complaints about the product?

Revision

This document is to be reviewed annually during management review meetings.

Revision no	Content changed	Reason for revision
00	Addition: • Ensure that the Investigation and decision on complaints/appeals shall not result in any discriminatory actions. • Ensure that the decision reviewed, approved and communicated to the complainant by individual(s) not involved in the original PT/RM activities in question NB: Where resources do not permit this, any alternative approach shall not compromise impartiality.	Empowerment of constructive instruction of the procedure.

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